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LARGE PRINT

25 LESSONS FROM George Washington

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Wisdom, Faith, and Character From the Father of Our Country

CARY BERGERON



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25 LESSONS FROM GEORGE WASHINGTON

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Large Print Edition. Set in 16 pt type.

Before You Start

Most of what I knew about George Washington came from a dollar bill and a cherry tree. Then I started reading what he actually wrote, and I met a man of faith who was tired, unsure, and stubborn about doing the right thing anyway.

I wrote this for my family first: 25 short lessons, each with a story, his own words, and a question. A few times I set my own story next to his, because his lessons kept turning up in my life.

I pray one of them turns up in yours.

Cary Bergeron

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PART I

Character

Who he was when nobody was making him be anything.

LESSON 1 · SCENE

Power Is a Trust, Not a Prize

Tuesday, December 23, 1783. Annapolis, Maryland. The war is over, and the most famous man in America walks into the Maryland State House, where Congress is meeting.

He could have walked in as something else. Some of his officers had hinted that the country needed a strong hand, maybe even a king. The army loved him. Congress had little money and less power. If George Washington had wanted to keep the country, plenty of people would have let him.

Instead he stood up, unfolded a short speech, and read it. One congressman who was there wrote that his hand shook so badly he had to hold the paper with both

hands. When he finished, he handed back the commission that had made him Commander in Chief. No parade, no terms, no conditions.

The next morning he rode for home. He reached Mount Vernon on Christmas Eve.

I think about the size of that choice. Most of us never get offered a country. But we all get offered something to hold onto a little longer than we should.

Years ago I took a contract job fixing the marketing for one of our agency's clients. They paid me more than I had ever been paid and gave me twelve months to do it. I finished in nine, and they offered me even more to stay on full time. I said no. The job meant a long commute and travel, and my wife and I had a new baby daughter at home. I turned down more money to be there for my family.

It wasn't a country. But it was the same question: what is this really for?

> **THE LESSON**
>
> **The strongest people know when to set power down.**

"Having now finished the work assigned me, I retire from the great theatre of Action."

George Washington, Address to Congress on Resigning His Commission, December 23, 1783

★ **REFLECT**

What are you holding onto that someone else in your family is ready to carry?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 2 · LEGEND AND TRUTH

A Better Story Than the Cherry Tree

You know the story. Young George takes a new hatchet to his father's cherry tree. His father asks who did it. George says, "I cannot tell a lie," and confesses.

It is a wonderful story. It just may not have happened.

The tale first shows up in 1806, seven years after Washington died, in a popular biography by a traveling preacher and bookseller named Mason Locke Weems. Weems said he heard it from an elderly relative of the family, and he told it well. It has never turned up anywhere else.

Here is the good news: the real George Washington did not need the help.

When Congress made him Commander in Chief in June 1775, he told them he would take no salary. He asked only that they cover his expenses, and he kept a careful written account of every one for eight years. A man who keeps an honest ledger through a whole war does not need a made-up tree.

In our family, a good story tends to grow a little every time it gets told. We are a loud bunch too, though not all the time. Our friends even have a name for it: "Bergeroning" a story. In our defense, some of those stories really did happen that way.

But I've noticed something. The stories my kids ask for again are never the ones I dressed up. They're the plain ones, the true ones, where Dad got it wrong and owned it. Truth wears better than polish.

THE LESSON

The truth is usually a better story than the legend.

"I do not wish to make any proffit from it."

George Washington, accepting command of the Continental Army, June 16, 1775

★ REFLECT

Which story about you do people tell that you would like to set straight?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 3 · HIS OWN WORDS

Keep the Small Spark Burning

Sometime around 1747, a Virginia boy of about fifteen sat down with a quill and copied out 110 rules. They had come from an old book of manners, and some of them sound funny to us now. Don't kill fleas in front of other people. Don't spit in the fire. Don't talk with your mouth full.

But he copied every one, in his best hand, and he kept the pages for the rest of his life.

Most of the rules are about small things: how to stand, how to listen, how to treat people above you and below you. That's the point. Character is mostly small things done the same way every day, until they stop being rules and start being you.

The last rule on his list is the one I like best. It doesn't tell him how to sit or what to say. It tells him to guard something: a little spark of fire inside him called conscience.

My parents taught me right from wrong through our faith. The rule that stuck with me most is one Jesus gave: do unto others as you would have them do unto you. I thought I understood it. Then, in my early twenties, I was waiting tables in Florida. Before that, I'd been the customer who got short with a server when the food took forever or the thing I asked for never showed up. Once I was the one carrying the plates to make rent, I finally understood what that rule really means.

It's a simple rule. A child can say it. It takes a whole life to live it, and I'm still working on it. Some days the spark burns bright.

Some days I have to cup my hands around it and blow.

Now I hear myself saying it to my own kids, and I know where it came from.

THE LESSON

Character is small habits, kept until they become who you are.

"Labour to keep alive in your Breast that Little Spark of Celestial fire Called Conscience."

George Washington, Rules of Civility, Rule 110, copied about 1747

★ REFLECT

What rule did you learn as a child that you now hear yourself saying?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 4 · SCENE

Grown Gray in Your Service

Newburgh, New York. March 15, 1783. The fighting is mostly over, but the army hasn't been paid in months, and some officers are tired of waiting. Angry letters are passing around camp. There is talk of marching on Congress.

Washington calls the officers together in a long wooden building. He gives them a speech, asking them to be patient and to trust the country they had fought for. It doesn't land. The room stays cold.

So he pulls out a letter from a congressman, meaning to read it to them. He squints at it and stumbles over the words. Then he reaches into his coat and takes out a pair of spectacles. Most of the men had never seen him wear them.

According to officers who were there, he asked them to permit him to put on his spectacles, because he had grown gray, and almost blind, in the service of his country.

That did it. Hard men who had followed him through eight years of war started to cry. The trouble ended that afternoon. Not because of his argument, but because he let them see he was tired too.

When we brought home our German Shepherd puppy, I was sure I had it handled. I did not. She had more energy than our whole family put together, and halfway through a training session I finally admitted it to the trainer. Then I laughed at myself. That was the day she started listening, and I think it was because I finally did too.

We spend a lot of energy looking like we've got it together. Sometimes the strongest thing you can do is put on the reading glasses in front of everybody.

THE LESSON

Admitting you're worn out can do what a good argument can't.

"Gentlemen, you will permit me to put on my spectacles, for, I have grown not only gray, but almost blind in the service of my country."

George Washington at Newburgh, March 15, 1783, as remembered by officers who were there

★ **REFLECT**

Who in your life needs to see you be honest about how tired you are?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 5 · SCENE

Good-bye to the Men Who Stayed

New York City. December 4, 1783. Noon. The British are gone, and Washington's officers gather in the long room upstairs at Fraunces Tavern. There is food on the table. Nobody eats much.

Washington walks in, fills a glass, and raises it. He tells them that with a heart full of love and gratitude he now takes his leave, and he hopes their later days will be as happy as their earlier ones were honorable. Then he asks each man to come and take him by the hand.

General Knox is closest, so he goes first. Washington, crying, pulls him into an embrace. Then the next man. Then the next. One by one, they come forward, and nobody says a word.

One of the officers, Benjamin Tallmadge, wrote about it years later. He said he had never before seen such a scene of sorrow and weeping, and he hoped he never would again.

These were the men who stayed. Through the cold winters, the bad pay, the lost battles, they stayed.

It was 2021, and a small book business I'd started with a partner was falling apart at 2 a.m., one crashed server at a time. My wife didn't ask questions. She put a black coffee on the edge of the desk, said, "Drink this," and stayed. When it was finally fixed, I slept the morning away. I only nodded at her that night. I've been thanking her ever since, every way I know how.

Washington had a room full of officers. Most of us get one or two people who stay. That's plenty, if you remember to thank them.

THE LESSON

Thank the people who stayed, while you can still take them by the hand.

"With a heart full of love and gratitude, I now take leave of you."

George Washington at Fraunces Tavern, December 4, 1783, as remembered by Benjamin Tallmadge

★ REFLECT

Who stayed with you through your hardest season, and when did you last tell them?

★ ★ ★

PART II

Faith

The God he trusted, in his own words and in hard places.

LESSON 6 · HIS OWN WORDS

A Vine and a Fig Tree

In August 1790, President Washington visited Newport, Rhode Island. The Jewish congregation there sent him a letter of welcome, and he wrote back.

He could have sent a polite note. Instead he made a promise. The government of the United States, he wrote, "gives to bigotry no sanction, to persecution no assistance." Then he reached for a verse from the prophet Micah, one he came back to again and again in his letters: everyone would "sit in safety under his own vine and figtree, and there shall be none to make him afraid."

That is a farmer's picture of freedom. Not a parade. A man on his own ground, in the shade of something he planted, with no one coming up the lane to take it from him.

Washington was a farmer before he was anything else, and I think he meant it plainly.

It is also a believer's picture. He did not invent the promise. He borrowed it from Scripture and handed it to a congregation that had been driven from one country after another.

My vine and fig tree is outside on our own land: the greenhouse, the garden, a row that needs working, the front porch at the end of the day. For about nine months of the year, while it is warm enough to be out there, I soak in every bit of it. The other three, I wait for spring.

Nobody hands you that kind of peace. Somebody has to plant it, and somebody has to protect it. Most nights on the porch I remember that I'm sitting in the shade of a lot of people's work, and of God's goodness more than anybody's.

THE LESSON

Freedom looks like ordinary people safe at home.

"Every one shall sit in safety under his own vine and figtree, and there shall be none to make him afraid."

George Washington, Letter to the Hebrew Congregation in Newport, Rhode Island, August 1790 (quoting Micah 4:4)

★ REFLECT

Where is your vine and fig tree, and when did you last sit under it?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 7 · SCENE

Four Bullets Through the Coat

July 9, 1755. The Monongahela River, in the woods of western Pennsylvania. George Washington is 23 years old and riding with a British army under General Edward Braddock.

They never see the attack coming. French soldiers and their Native allies open fire from the trees, and the long red column falls apart. Officers on horseback make easy targets, and one after another they go down. Braddock is mortally wounded.

Washington, sick with a fever and riding on a cushion tied to his saddle, keeps moving through it all, carrying orders and trying to hold the men together. When it's over, he helps lead the survivors out.

Nine days later he wrote to his younger brother. He didn't brag. He reported, almost plainly, that four bullets had gone through his coat and two horses had been shot out from under him, and he hadn't been hurt. And he knew exactly who to credit for that: Providence.

It was a November night on I-25, snow coming sideways and black ice under everything. Cars were spinning out in both lanes when a semi ahead of me lost its grip and jackknifed across the shoulder. My foot found the brake, and the tires found just enough dry ground by the median to stop me short of the trailer. Afterward I sat in the quiet with my hands locked on the wheel, thinking about how close I'd come to not making it home to my wife. I call that grace. I don't have a better word for it.

Washington spent the rest of his life believing he'd been kept for a reason. I'm not sure I know my reason yet. But I know I was kept.

THE LESSON

When you've been spared, say thank you to the One who spared you.

"By the all powerful dispensations of Providence, I have been protected beyond all human probability and expectation; for I had four bullets through my coat, and two horses shot under me, yet escaped unhurt."

George Washington to John Augustine Washington, July 18, 1755 (spelling modernized)

★ REFLECT

When were you protected in a way you couldn't explain, and who have you told?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 8 · HIS OWN WORDS

A Chaplain for Every Regiment

July 9, 1776. New York. Five days earlier, in Philadelphia, Congress had approved the Declaration of Independence. Washington's army is camped in and around the city, waiting for the largest British fleet anyone has ever seen.

That day he issued his General Orders, the instructions read out to the whole army. In them he arranged for every regiment to have a chaplain, and he asked the colonels to find men of good character and exemplary lives.

Then he told the soldiers why. The blessing and protection of Heaven, he wrote, are always needed, and especially in times of public distress and danger. He hoped every

officer and every man would live and act as a Christian soldier defending the dearest rights and liberties of his country.

He didn't treat faith as a decoration on the army. He put it in the orders, right next to the guard duty and the supply lists, because to him it belonged there.

When the pressure of running a business and keeping up with client work made everything feel too loud, my pastor has always been the steady voice that cut through it. One day I was sitting in the cafe at church, and I must have looked as rough as I felt, because he noticed. He came over and asked what was on my mind. For some reason that one question almost brought me to tears. We talked for a while, and he shared a passage from Proverbs that has stayed with me ever since:

> *Let your eyes look directly ahead and let your gaze be fixed straight in front of you. Watch the path of your feet and all your ways will be established. Do not turn to the right nor to the left; turn your foot from evil.*
>
> Proverbs 4:25–27 (NASB 1995)

Every one of us needs a chaplain in our regiment. Somebody who isn't impressed by the noise. Somebody who will point back up when we've been staring at the ground too long.

THE LESSON

Keep a steady voice of faith close, especially when life gets loud.

"The blessing and protection of Heaven are at all times necessary but especially so in times of public distress and danger."

George Washington, General Orders, July 9, 1776

★ **REFLECT**

Who is the chaplain in your regiment, and when did you last thank them?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 9 · LEGEND AND TRUTH

The Winter at Valley Forge

There's a well-loved painting of George Washington kneeling in the snow at Valley Forge, praying alone beside his horse. You've probably seen it on a wall somewhere. It's a beautiful picture, and it's been told and retold for more than two hundred years.

Nobody at camp wrote that moment down. But the true story of that winter is every bit as moving.

The army marched into Valley Forge, Pennsylvania, on December 19, 1777. They were worn out after a season of defeats. Food ran short. Blankets ran short. Plenty of men had no shoes, and the snow showed where they'd walked. They built

log huts with their own hands. Nearly two thousand of them died that winter, most of them from sickness.

Washington could have taken quarters somewhere comfortable. He stayed. He wrote letter after letter begging for supplies, and come spring he thanked his men for their uncomplaining patience. When the army marched out on June 19, 1778, it was smaller, but it was tougher, better trained, and ready to fight.

Our greenhouse runs on a motto: “Grow slow. Grow strong.” The first part comes easy. A Colorado winter makes sure nothing grows fast, no matter how many times you check on it. The second part takes faith. You water, you wait, and you trust that the roots are doing their job down where you can’t see. Washington spent a whole winter at Valley Forge doing exactly that, just with a lot less heat.

The painting shows a man praying in the snow. The record shows a man who stayed. I think you can believe both.

> **THE LESSON**
>
> **Hard seasons grow strong roots, if you stay.**

"Uncomplaining Patience during the scarcity of provisions in Camp."

George Washington, praising his soldiers at Valley Forge, General Orders, March 1, 1778

★ **REFLECT**

What hard season are you in right now that might be growing roots?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 10 · HIS OWN WORDS

Give Thanks Out Loud

October 3, 1789. New York, which was then the capital. George Washington has been President for about five months. The new government is untested, and a lot of people are waiting to see whether it will hold.

That fall, Congress asked him to set aside a day for the whole country to give thanks. So he wrote a proclamation, the first one ever issued by a President of the United States.

It opens with a simple claim: that it is the duty of every nation to acknowledge the providence of Almighty God, to obey His will, to be grateful for His benefits, and to ask humbly for His protection. Then he names a day, Thursday, November 26, and

asks the people to spend it thanking God for His care, for the peace they'd won, and for the chance to govern themselves.

He didn't ask people to feel thankful quietly. He asked them to say it out loud, together.

Thanksgiving at our house is turkey, mashed potatoes and pumpkin pie. A couple of years we tried something different. It was fine. It just wasn't Thanksgiving, and we went right back.

This year I'm thankful for something I didn't see coming a year ago: watching one of our girls find her footing. I'll be saying so at the table, out loud, even if somebody rolls their eyes. Gratitude kept in your head is only half done.

> THE LESSON
>
> **Gratitude grows when you say it out loud.**

"It is the duty of all Nations to acknowledge the providence of Almighty God, to obey his will, to be grateful for his benefits, and humbly to implore his protection and favor."

George Washington, Thanksgiving Proclamation, October 3, 1789

★ **REFLECT**

What are you thankful for this year that you haven't said out loud yet?

★ ★ ★

PART III

Courage

Nights when quitting made more sense than going on.

LESSON 11 · SCENE

Into the Fog

Brooklyn, New York. August 29, 1776. Two days ago, the British beat Washington's army badly on Long Island. Now about 9,000 American soldiers are packed onto Brooklyn Heights. The British army is in front of them. The East River is behind them, and the British navy could close it any time the wind turns.

It looks like the end of the war, less than two months after the Declaration.

That night Washington gathers every rowboat and flat-bottomed boat he can find. Fishermen from Massachusetts, men who knew boats better than anyone, take the oars. The soldiers are told to move without a sound. Regiment by regiment, all

night long, they slip down to the ferry landing and across the mile of black water to Manhattan.

By dawn there are still men on the Brooklyn shore. And then a heavy fog rolls in off the water and hides them. When it finally lifts, the British find empty trenches. Washington, who had said he would leave on the last boat, was in one of the final boats across.

Years ago, after I sold a business, I spent a stretch not knowing what came next, and the money was running low. My wife never once made me feel like I'd failed. She just kept telling me that with God's help I could do anything. Within three months I'd found my way into the next business. I still think about how thick that fog felt, and how she walked me out of it.

Sometimes courage isn't charging ahead. Sometimes it's getting everybody home safe in the dark, and trusting God to send the fog.

THE LESSON

When you can't see the way, keep rowing and trust God with the fog.

"Remember officers and Soldiers that you are Freemen, fighting for the blessings of Liberty."

George Washington, General Orders, August 23, 1776

★ REFLECT

Who walked you through your foggiest season, and do they know it?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 12 · TURNING POINT

Christmas Night on the Delaware

December 1776. The American cause is close to finished. The army has been chased out of New York and across New Jersey. Thousands of soldiers' enlistments run out on December 31. Many people have quietly decided the war is lost.

A few days before Christmas, Washington wrote to a friend that necessity, dire necessity, would have to justify what he was about to try.

On Christmas night he loaded about 2,400 men into boats and took them across the ice-choked Delaware River in a storm of sleet and snow. The password that night was "Victory or Death." The crossing ran

hours behind schedule. Then they marched all night, nine miles, some of them with rags around their feet.

At eight in the morning on December 26 they hit the Hessian garrison at Trenton. In about an hour it was over. Nearly 900 enemy soldiers were taken prisoner. The Americans lost two men, both of whom froze to death on the march. Word spread fast, and a country that had nearly given up decided to keep going.

When I left a good-paying corporate job to build something of my own, plenty of good people thought I'd lost my mind. Maybe they had a point. I worked twice as hard as I ever had on salary, with my faith and my family behind me. It took more years than I realized at the time, but that business grew into one I was able to sell.

The crossing is always colder than you expect. It's worth it on the other side.

THE LESSON

Some crossings only get made when you decide there's no going back.

"Necessity, dire necessity, will, nay must, justify an attempt."

George Washington to Joseph Reed, December 23, 1776

★ REFLECT

What river have you been standing beside, waiting for the weather to clear?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 13 · THEN AND NOW

Haul the Cannons Home

The winter of 1775. Washington has the British army bottled up in Boston, but he has almost no heavy guns to do anything about it. A 25-year-old Boston bookseller named Henry Knox says he knows where to get some: Fort Ticonderoga, about 300 miles away in New York, where the Americans had captured a pile of cannons that spring.

Knox had read a lot of books about artillery. He had never moved any. Washington sent him anyway.

Knox and his men loaded 59 cannons and mortars onto ox sleds and dragged them through snow, across frozen lakes and rivers, and over the Berkshire Mountains. Some of the guns broke through the ice

and had to be fished out. It took weeks. They reached the army in late January 1776.

Then, on the night of March 4, Washington's men hauled the guns up onto Dorchester Heights, the hills above Boston, and dug in before sunrise. The British woke up to cannons pointed at them. Within two weeks they had packed up and sailed away.

Two summers ago I climbed my first fourteener, Mount Sherman. I should mention I'm afraid of heights. Near the top there was a stretch where one wrong step could have been the last one. So I stopped right there and prayed. Then I kept going, one step at a time, and at the top I saw the most beautiful view of my life.

Knox didn't move the cannons in one heave. Nobody climbs a mountain in one step. The hard thing gets done one pull,

one step, one prayer at a time.

THE LESSON

Big things get moved one hard step at a time.

"I hope in 16 or 17 days to be able to present to your Excellency a Noble train of Artillery."

Henry Knox to George Washington, December 17, 1775

★ **REFLECT**

What heavy thing are you dragging toward the hill right now, and what's the next step?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 14 · TURNING POINT

Learn From a Stranger

February 23, 1778. Valley Forge. A stranger rides into camp: a Prussian officer named Friedrich Wilhelm von Steuben. He speaks almost no English. He has come to help.

Washington's army is brave, but it isn't really one army. Every regiment marches, loads and drills its own way. Washington could have been too proud to take lessons from a foreigner who couldn't even talk to his men. Instead he put von Steuben to work.

Von Steuben started with a single model company of about a hundred men and drilled them himself. He shouted orders in German and French, and a young aide turned them into English. He swore at the men in three languages, and they laughed, and they learned. Then those men went

back and taught everyone else. He even wrote the drill down so it could be taught the same way everywhere.

By June, the ragged army that had limped into Valley Forge marched out in step. At the Battle of Monmouth that summer, they stood and fought like professionals.

What strikes me is how many people had to be humble for that to work. Washington had to trust a stranger. Proud American soldiers had to take orders from a man who couldn't speak their language. And von Steuben had to learn that free men want to know why.

Most of what I know, somebody taught me who didn't have to. The one who taught me humility was my wife. Growing up, I was arrogant. I figured I knew better than everyone, and maybe that I was better than

everyone too. She never lectured me about it. She just lived humbly, day after day, until I finally started to see it.

> **THE LESSON**
>
> **Be humble enough to learn from anyone who knows more than you.**

"You say to your soldier, 'Do this,' and he doeth it; but I am obliged to say, 'This is the reason why you ought to do that,' and then he does it."

Baron von Steuben, in a 1787 letter to a fellow Prussian officer, as translated by Friedrich Kapp

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★ **REFLECT**

Who could teach you something right now, if you were willing to ask?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 15 · SCENE

Win Like a Gentleman

October 19, 1781. Yorktown, Virginia. After weeks of siege by American and French troops, with a French fleet blocking the bay, the British army surrenders.

The British troops march out between two long lines of soldiers, Americans on one side and French on the other. A band plays. Thousands of people have come to watch.

The British commander, Lord Cornwallis, doesn't come. He says he's ill and sends his second in command to hand over his sword. The deputy first tries to give it to the French general, who points him to Washington. Washington doesn't take it either. He directs the man to his own second in command, General Benjamin Lincoln, who had been forced to surrender to the British at Charleston the year before.

There is no gloating. No speech about how great the victory was. Washington wrote a short note to Congress that day, plain and polite, and then got to work on what came next. A few days later he even hosted the defeated British officers at dinner.

Winning is a test, the same as losing is. Anybody can be gracious when they've lost and have no choice. It takes real character to be gracious when you're on top and nobody would blame you for crowing.

Washington had waited six years for that afternoon. He spent it making sure everyone kept their dignity.

> THE LESSON
>
> **Win in a way that lets the other side keep their dignity.**

“I have the Honor to inform Congress, that a Reduction of the British Army under the Command of Lord Cornwallis, is most happily effected.”

George Washington to the President of Congress, October 19, 1781

★ **REFLECT**

The next time you win, how will you make the other side feel?

★ ★ ★

PART IV

Home and the Land

The farmer, the husband, and the man who always wanted to go home.

LESSON 16 · HIS OWN WORDS

Seven Times Seven Years

Philadelphia. June 18, 1775. Two days ago, the Continental Congress made George Washington Commander in Chief of an army that barely existed yet. Tomorrow or the next day he'll ride north to Boston to take charge of it. He has no idea it will be more than six years before he sleeps at Mount Vernon again.

Before he goes, he sits down to write the hardest letter of the week. It's to Martha.

He tells her he didn't go looking for this. He tried to get out of it. He'd rather be home with her. And then he writes one of the most tender lines any general ever put on paper: that he would enjoy more real happiness in one month with her, at home,

than he could ever hope to find out in the world, even if he stayed away seven times seven years.

Forty-nine years, and he'd still trade them for one month on the porch with his wife.

He went anyway, because he believed he'd been called. But he never pretended it didn't cost him. And Martha came to him at winter camp after camp, through most of the war, including that hard winter at Valley Forge.

I think about that letter when I'm sitting on our porch at the end of the day. Most of what the world offers to pull a man away from home is real. The money is real. The chance is real. So is the ache of being gone, if he's honest about it. I learned that on a business trip that ran a lot longer than it should have. I ached to get home to my wife and family, and before I got back I

made myself a promise: change the way I do business so I'm never gone that long again.

Washington was honest about it. That might be the most romantic thing about him.

THE LESSON

Tell the people at home what they're worth to you, in plain words.

"I should enjoy more real happiness and felicity in one month with you, at home, than I have the most distant prospect of reaping abroad, if my stay was to be Seven times Seven years."

George Washington to Martha Washington, June 18, 1775

★ REFLECT

When did you last tell the person at home, in plain words, what they're worth to you?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 17 · TURNING POINT

When the Soil Tells You

Mount Vernon, the 1760s. Like almost every big farmer in Virginia, Washington grows tobacco. It's what his father grew. It's what everybody grows. It's how a Virginia gentleman measures himself.

There's just one problem. It isn't working.

Tobacco wears out the soil fast. Year after year his crops come in thinner. And because the leaf gets shipped to merchants in England, who set the price and take their cut, he often ends up owing them money. He studies the numbers, he studies the dirt, and he comes to a conclusion that a lot of his neighbors weren't ready to hear.

In 1766 he stops making tobacco his main crop and switches to wheat. By the next year he has given up tobacco almost completely. He builds up a mill to grind his

own flour, sells it in more than one market, and starts rotating his fields so the ground gets a rest.

It was a big change for a man to make in his thirties, in a place where everyone did things one way. But the soil was telling him something, and he listened.

Any gardener knows that feeling. Here in Colorado, the ground and the weather have their own opinions, and they don't care how much you wanted something to grow. We had a bad batch of compost once that poisoned our beds, and there wasn't anything to do but clear them out and start over.

Pride says keep doing what you've always done. Wisdom says look at what's actually coming up.

THE LESSON

Pay attention to what the ground is telling you, and be willing to change.

"I think with you that the life of a husbandman is the most delectable. It is honorable, it is amusing."

George Washington, in a letter to the English farming writer Arthur Young

★ **REFLECT**

What in your life is the soil trying to tell you, and are you listening?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 18 · THEN AND NOW

Write Down the Weather

Thursday, January 22, 1789. Mount Vernon. In a few months George Washington will be sworn in as the first President of the United States. What does he write in his diary that day?

The weather.

The thermometer read 32 in the morning, 36 at noon and 32 at night. It snowed, hailed and rained, more or less all day, with the wind out of the northeast.

That's it. And he did it nearly every day, for years. Morning, noon and night temperatures. Which way the wind blew. Rain, frost, heat, a storm in the night. Page after page, in a small, steady hand.

It doesn't sound like much. But it was how he came to know his land better than almost anyone. Small notes, kept faithfully,

told him when to plant, when to harvest, which fields drained and which ones flooded. One day of weather is trivia. Twenty years of it is wisdom.

Most of the habits that hold a life together look like that from the outside. Small. Repetitive. Nobody claps for them.

In our greenhouse, the cucumbers and squash don't have bees to do the work, so I hand-pollinate them, one flower at a time. Nobody sees it. Nobody would ever know if I skipped a morning, until the plants came up empty.

Washington's weather notes never made him famous. They made him a good farmer. Some things are worth doing because nobody's watching.

> THE LESSON
>
> **Small things done every day add up to wisdom.**

“Thermometer at 32 in the Morning—36 at Noon and 32 at Night. Snowing, hailing & raining more or less all day—with the Wind at No. Et.”

George Washington, Diary, January 22, 1789

★ **REFLECT**

What small daily habit do you keep that everything else depends on?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 19 · SCENE

A Barn With Sixteen Sides

Dogue Run Farm, Mount Vernon. 1792. George Washington is President of the United States, busy setting up a whole new government in Philadelphia. And somewhere in the middle of all that, he's drawing up plans for a barn.

Not just any barn. He had a problem to solve. The usual way to get wheat off the stalk was to spread it on the ground outdoors and let horses trample it. The grain got dirty, some of it got lost, and if it rained, the whole crop could spoil.

So he designed something nobody around him had seen: a round, two-story barn with sixteen sides. Horses would walk in circles on the upper floor, treading out the wheat. The floorboards had small gaps between them, so the loose grain fell

straight through to the floor below, clean and dry, where it could be gathered up and stored. The straw stayed on top.

He worked out the plans himself, figured out the number of bricks and boards it would take, and sent detailed instructions home to his farm manager. It was built between 1792 and 1794. Today Mount Vernon has a working reconstruction you can walk into.

I love that the President of the United States still had dirt under his fingernails, at least in his head. He never stopped being a farmer who looked at a problem and asked, “How could this work better?”

Every greenhouse, garden and shop has a few of those problems. The stuff you can buy doesn’t quite fit, so you rig something up that does.

The best fixes don't come from catalogs. They come from people who know the ground they stand on.

> **THE LESSON**
>
> **When nothing does the job right, build something that does.**

"How much more delightful to an undebauched mind is the task of making improvements on the earth than all the vain glory which can be acquired from ravaging it."

George Washington, in a letter to Arthur Young

★ **REFLECT**

What problem in your home or work could you solve with your own hands this year?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 20 · TURNING POINT

The Children He Raised

November 1781. Yorktown is won, and George Washington should be celebrating the biggest victory of his life. Instead he's hurrying to a plantation called Eltham, where Martha's son Jack lies sick with a fever he caught in the army camps.

Washington had raised Jack since the boy was about four. Jack had come along on the Yorktown campaign as a volunteer aide. Now he was dying, at just 26. He died on November 5, 1781, leaving a young widow and four small children.

Washington had just outlasted the British Empire. Now he had a grieving family to look after.

Jack's widow agreed to let George and Martha take the two youngest children, a little girl named Nelly, about two years old,

and a baby boy everyone called Wash, six months old. They grew up at Mount Vernon. Washington never formally adopted them, but it hardly mattered. He paid for their schooling, worried over their manners and their studies, and treated them as his own.

George Washington is called the Father of His Country. He never had children of his own. But he was a father, more than once, to children who needed one.

Over the years my wife and I have helped raise three of our nieces and nephews. They needed more than they were getting, and we were in a position to give it. It wasn't always easy. But when it's family, you don't wait for someone else to step up. You just do it.

Nobody gets to pick the children God puts in their path. You only get to pick whether you'll show up for them.

THE LESSON

Family is the people you step up for when they need you.

★ REFLECT

Is there a child in your family or your town who could use one more grown-up showing up for them?

★ ★ ★

PART V

Legacy

How he finished, and what he left the rest of us.

LESSON 21 · HIS OWN WORDS

Summoned by My Country

April 30, 1789. New York City. A huge crowd fills Wall Street and every window and rooftop around Federal Hall. On the balcony, George Washington puts his hand on a Bible and takes the oath as the first President of the United States. The crowd roars. Cannons fire.

Then he goes inside to give his first speech as President, and the most striking thing about it is how unsure he sounds.

He tells Congress he was "summoned by my Country, whose voice I can never hear but with veneration and love." He'd been happy at home. He'd hoped to grow old there. And he admits, plainly, that he doubts whether he has the gifts the job will take. People who were there said his hands trembled and his voice was low. A senator

wrote that the great soldier seemed more nervous facing that room than he ever had facing cannon.

This was the most admired man in America. He'd won a war. And he walked into the hardest job in the country feeling like he wasn't ready for it.

He did it anyway, because the country asked.

I find that comforting. Most of the big things we're asked to do in life, we don't feel ready for. Being a husband. Being a dad. Being the one people turn to when something breaks. If you wait until you feel ready, you'll mostly wait.

Washington's answer to the call wasn't confidence. It was humility and duty, and a prayer that God would make up the difference. Right there in that same speech, he asked for exactly that.

THE LESSON

You don't have to feel ready to answer the call.

"I was summoned by my Country, whose voice I can never hear but with veneration and love."

George Washington, First Inaugural Address, April 30, 1789

★ REFLECT

What is calling you right now that you've been waiting to feel ready for?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 22 · TURNING POINT

Two Terms and Home

September 1796. George Washington has been President for almost eight years. He's 64. He's tired. And he could almost certainly be elected again if he let his name stand.

He doesn't. In a long letter to the American people, printed in a Philadelphia newspaper that September, he tells the country he will not serve another term. Then he finishes out his last months, hands the office to John Adams in March 1797, and goes home to Mount Vernon.

It's easy to miss how unusual that was. Kings didn't step down. Generals didn't give back armies. Powerful men, then and now, have a way of deciding that nobody

else could possibly do the job. Washington decided the opposite: that the country needed to learn it could go on without him.

It did. For nearly 150 years after that, no President served more than two terms. The tradition he started was so strong that the country later wrote it into the Constitution.

This is the second time in this book he walked away from power. The first was his army, in Lesson 1. The second was the presidency. Most people never get to set down that much, even once.

But every one of us eventually has to step back from something that's still going well. A job. A role. A way of doing things that was ours for a long time. Knowing when your season is done, and leaving room for the next person to grow, takes as much strength as holding on ever did.

Washington didn't leave because he had to. He left because it was right.

THE LESSON

Leave while it's going well, and leave room for someone else to grow.

"I should now apprize you of the resolution I have formed, to decline being considered among the number of those, out of whom a choice is to be made."

George Washington, Farewell Address, September 19, 1796

★ **REFLECT**

What season in your life is ending, and who is ready to take your place?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 23 · HIS OWN WORDS

The Name of American

September 19, 1796. The same long letter in which Washington told the country he was going home, the one we now call his Farewell Address, was also his last big piece of advice to the people he'd served.

He had watched the young country argue. North and South. East and West. City and farm. He knew how easily people start thinking of themselves first by where they're from, and only second as part of the whole.

So he asked Americans to remember what they shared. They had the same faith, much the same customs, and the same hard-won freedom. They had fought side by side, suffered together and won together. And then he wrote the line that's stayed with me: that the name of

American, which belongs to every one of us, must always matter more than any local label.

He wasn't telling people to stop loving their states or their towns. He loved Virginia. He was telling them to love something bigger too.

I can't point to one moment when I felt proudest to be an American. It's grown on me a little at a time: Fourth of July fireworks, summer barbecues, long road trips, and the plain fact that here, if you're willing to work hard, you're free to build something and to worship God while you do it. Our little town has one stoplight on Main Street, and I wouldn't trade it for any city. The folks here watch out for each other, help each other, and hold on to their faith. That's as American as it gets.

Washington wanted us to carry the name with pride. I try to.

THE LESSON

What we share as Americans is worth more than what divides us.

"The name of AMERICAN, which belongs to you, in your national capacity, must always exalt the just pride of Patriotism, more than any appellation derived from local discriminations."

George Washington, Farewell Address, September 19, 1796

★ REFLECT

What small, everyday thing makes you proud to be an American?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 24 · SCENE

'Tis Well

Mount Vernon. December 1799. Washington is 67, retired, and riding out over his farms most days, the way he always has. On Thursday, December 12, he spends hours on horseback in rain, sleet and snow. He comes in late and sits down to dinner without changing his wet clothes.

By the next night his throat is so sore he can barely speak. By the early hours of December 14, he can hardly breathe. The doctors come and do everything they knew to do in those days, and none of it helps.

He knows. And what strikes everyone around him is how calm he is.

He asks Martha to bring him his two wills and burns the old one. He has his secretary, Tobias Lear, put his letters and accounts in order. He thanks the doctors

for their care and asks them to stop troubling themselves. Several times he apologizes to the people looking after him for all the trouble he's causing.

Late that night he tells Lear, "I am just going," and gives a few simple instructions for his burial. Then he asks, "Do you understand me?" Lear says yes. Washington's last words are two: "'Tis well."

That's how I'd like to finish. Not afraid. Not grasping. Papers in order, people thanked, and peace with God.

My best friend was more of a brother to me than some brothers are. He passed away many years ago, but I still hear him. He taught me to be myself and not to worry about what other people thought of me, because their opinions never made anybody a better person. I'm still trying to live the way he did.

A good finish starts a long time before the end. It's built every day you live as the person you mean to be.

> **THE LESSON**
>
> **Live so that at the end you can say, "It is well."**

"'Tis well."

George Washington's last words, December 14, 1799, as recorded by Tobias Lear

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★ **REFLECT**

What would have to be in order for you to say "'Tis well"?

★ ★ ★

LESSON 25 · THEN AND NOW

Plant Trees You Won't Sit Under

Mount Vernon. Spring 1785. The war has been over for more than a year. George Washington is finally home, and his diary for those months is full of one thing: trees.

He rides out into his own woods looking for young ones, the straightest and healthiest he can find. Tulip poplars. Dogwoods. Redbuds. Elms. Pines. His workers dig them up and carry them back, and he plants them around the house, along the lanes and across the bowling green, sketching out where each one should go. Some die. He plants more. Day after day the diary keeps track of what he moved, where it went, and how the weather treated it.

He was 53. He knew perfectly well he wouldn't see most of those trees at their full height.

He planted them anyway. And some of the trees from his time still stand at Mount Vernon today, more than two hundred years later, shading visitors he never could have imagined.

This year I planted an oak tree in the northwest corner of our property. I've always loved oaks. They're strong, they handle the cold, and they spread a canopy wide enough to shade a whole family. An oak can live a hundred years or more, so I'll never see this one full grown. That's all right. It isn't really for me. It's for whoever is standing in that corner long after I'm gone.

That's what this whole book has been about, really. Washington didn't just win a war or start a government. He planted

things: habits, a way of leading, a country that would outlive him. We're standing in his shade.

Now it's our turn to plant.

THE LESSON

The best things you do will be enjoyed by people you'll never meet.

"The preservation of the sacred fire of liberty, and the destiny of the Republican model of Government, are justly considered as deeply, perhaps as finally staked, on the experiment entrusted to the hands of the American people."

George Washington, First Inaugural Address, April 30, 1789

★ REFLECT

What can you plant this year that someone in your family will sit under long after you're gone?

★ ★ ★

About the Author

Cary Bergeron is a husband, a dad, and a believer who lives in Berthoud, Colorado. He spent his career in technology and marketing and co-founded CraveBooks, a platform that helps readers find their next book.

These days you'll find him in the greenhouse, out in the orchard, or on the front porch with his wife and their German Shepherd. Rooted In Liberty is his way of building something that lasts, for his family and yours.

There's more where these came from.

101 Lessons From George Washington, the full book, is on the way, along with more titles from the Rooted In Liberty Library on faith, history, and the founders.

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